

To: Parents/Guardians of Elementary School

From: Madison Gelfand

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Subject: Healthy Tech at Home

Families, during recess, there has been a significant increase in peer-to-peer verbal and physical conflict. After analyzing the root causes, we have discovered that the majority of these conflicts initially stem from group chat forums students are engaging in outside of school hours. The purpose of this memo is to provide information on how to monitor your child's online activity to help us mitigate these conflicts outside of school, which in turn will support our efforts to decrease friction during the school day. As a school staff, we are having ongoing conversations with students about what it means to be respectful and how to resolve conflicts. We have also discussed explicit steps students should take to involve a staff member if a situation escalates. Additionally, teachers are working diligently to monitor outdoor recess to ensure that students are playing safely and respectfully. With support at home, we can significantly decrease these peer-to-peer conflicts.

Studies show that children are more prone to socioemotional challenges when highly engaged with electronics, with significant effects tending to be anxiety, depression, aggression, and hyperactivity (Vasconcellos et al., 2025). Furthermore, cyberbullying has risen sharply since the COVID-19 pandemic, with research showing between one-third and one-half of children experiencing online bullying at some point (Waasdorp, 2025). Beyond the immediate social interactions, a lack of sleep caused by late-night device use directly decreases a child's ability to regulate their emotions, especially in stressful peer situations (Muppalla et al., 2023; Ruder,

2019). While technology has many benefits, these behavioral consequences require careful collaborative management.

To help regulate conflicts that stem from online group chats, please consider taking a few key actions at home to support your child's technology health. First, teach your child the phrase "Freeze before you 'tease,'" meaning they should pause and think about what they are going to type before they actually do so. Because tone is easily lost through text, what one child finds funny may come across as deeply disrespectful to another, and pausing can prevent these painful miscommunications. Second, stay up-to-date on the games and apps your child is using by asking them to show you how they work, ensuring you know how to navigate the applications yourself. Another strategy is to make upfront technology agreements with your children about when they can use devices, who they should be talking to, and what platforms they may use, with consequences clearly laid out. Finally, creating a centralized charging station for devices before bedtime can allow children's brains time to wind down and help them sleep without the late-night disruption of a device by their bedside.

To support these healthy habits at school, teachers will continue to strictly monitor device usage and digital citizenship during school hours. Teachers will also establish classroom technology agreements with students to reinforce proper usage, implementing temporary breaks from devices if needed. Finally, we will be teaching explicit social-emotional lessons on how to implement the "Freeze before you 'tease'" strategy, focusing on how respectful in-person interactions extend directly to online communication. Working together, we can ensure our students are well-rested, ready to learn, and growing into responsible, kind individuals both inside and outside of school.

References

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Connection to ISTE Educational Leader Standards

This activity aligns directly with the ISTE Standards for Education Leaders, specifically Standard 3.1.c (Model Inclusive, Healthy Use) and Standard 3.1.d (Model Safe, Ethical, Legal Use). The memo addresses Standard 3.1.c by explicitly demonstrating how excessive device use impacts a child's socioemotional health and sleep quality. It provides families with actionable strategies, such as establishing centralized charging stations and managing evening screen time, to actively support student well-being. Furthermore, the memo supports Standard 3.1.d by outlining how educators actively teach digital citizenship. By guiding students to be mindful during online communication and helping them understand how text-based tone can trigger peer conflict, the initiative proactively prevents digital miscommunications from disrupting the school environment.